is also known as the Slave dynasty because the rulers were originally Turkish Mamluks or soldiers with slave origins.[76] Slaves were reputed for their loyalty, as noted in the saying ‘one obedient slave is better than three hundred sons, for the latter desire their father’s death, the former his master’s glory’, though they would often revolt and usurp power themselves.[77] Qutb al-Din Aybak, after whom the famous Qutb Minar in Delhi is named, was originally a military slave of Sultan Ghuri, as was Shams al-Din Iltutmish, a successor and slave of Aybak.

In the warfare of subsequent centuries in the north-west, captives from India would also be taken to central Asia in large numbers, often traded for horses, giving rise to a saying of those times: ‘Slaves from India, horses from Parthia.’[78] According to Ibn Battuta, the 14th century traveller who had noted the presence of Indians among the troops of the Byzantine Empire, the Hindu Kush range in the north-west frontier of the Indian subcontinent was called so because the name meant ‘slayer of Hindus’ who experienced high mortality due to the intensity of the cold when they were taken across as slaves.[79]

Between the mid-15th and mid-17th centuries, the slave markets of the Arab world began importing *Habshi* slaves from Ethiopia as servants or for re-export to meet the demand for military labour in the Deccan plateau, and sometimes in exchange for Indian textiles.[80] Arguably the most famous of these slaves, Malik Ambar, earlier known as Chapu, was born in Ethiopia in 1548 CE, taken to the slave markets of west Asia and exported to the Deccan where he was purchased by the Nizam Shahi of the Sultanate of Ahmadnagar (1496-1636 CE). The person who bought him, one Chengiz Khan, the peshwa or chief minister, was himself a former slave and a Habshi. He was only following what was by then a well-established practice of importing African slaves from the Persian Gulf region to the Deccan kingdoms via the Konkan seaports on the west coast. The Arab dhows would take a few weeks to cross the Arabian Sea to deliver the slaves, known as *ghulam*s in Arabic and *banda*s in Persian.

Ambar’s subsequent upward mobility was stunning, mirroring the Turkish Mamluks of Delhi in the 13th century. Once his master died, he was